Key dates

Nasser closed the Straits of Tiran to Israeli shipping: 22 May 1967

Jordan signed a defence treaty with Egypt: 30 May 1967

the Israeli side of the border but the Israelis refused, so the UN troops were withdrawn.

- Thirdly, on 22 May Nasser closed the Straits of Tiran, which led into the Gulf of Aqaba, to Israeli shipping (see the map on page 52). The Israelis regarded this as 'an act of aggression' against Israel, and claimed that the USA, France and Britain had 'guaranteed' free passage for all shipping through the Gulf of Aqaba in 1957.

Meanwhile, a war fever was being whipped up in the press and radio in several Arab states. On 24 May 1967 the Syrian Defence Minister challenged the Israelis: 'We shall never call for, nor accept peace. We have resolved to drench this land with your blood and throw you into the sea for good.'

Israel's response

Among the Israeli public, many feared a repeat of 1948 as the country was surrounded by warlike Arab states. Israeli military leaders knew that an Arab invasion was not imminent but were now keen to go to war and they were confident of victory. However, the Israeli government insisted on securing US support: they needed, for example, to be sure that the US government would stand by Israel in the UN if Israel attacked first. The US President told the Israelis that, according to US intelligence, Egypt had no plan to attack but that, if it did, then the Israelis would 'whip the hell out of them'. He then added: 'Israel will not be alone unless it decides to go it alone'. The Israeli government decided to wait.

Increased pressure on Israel

In Egypt, on 29 May, Nasser stepped up the pressure in a speech to the Egyptian parliament:

> We are now ready to confront Israel. The issue now at hand is not the Gulf of Aqaba, the Straits of Tiran, or the withdrawal of the UN forces, but the rights of the Palestine people. It is the aggression which took place in Palestine in 1948 with the collaboration of Britain and the United States.

He demanded that Israel should allow the Palestinian refugees to return to Israel and that Israel should give up the land taken in the 1948–9 war. Perhaps he thought that Israel would give way and he could win a victory without a war. In Jordan, King Hussein wanted to avoid war and remain neutral if fighting broke out. But half the population of Jordan was Palestinian, and newspapers and demonstrations demanded revenge for what had happened in 1948–9. On 30 May King Hussein signed a defence treaty with Egypt.